

January 16, 2024

Enrollment Policy Discussion Summary

BVSD has been anticipating a gradual decline in enrollment in future years. COVID-related enrollment loss accelerated this decline dramatically. Declining numbers of students can lead to budget reductions, inefficient facility operations and most importantly, a less comprehensive educational experience for students at schools with smaller populations.

Long Range Advisory Committee

In April 2022, the Board created the Long Range Advisory Committee (LRAC) to involve the community in guiding the district's response to enrollment decline. The committee met over the course of the school year to develop an understanding of the many interconnected factors that influence and are impacted by changes in enrollment. In June 2023, the committee provided the Board with a [final report of recommendations](#). The recommendations included a process and metrics for when the Board should take action related to the enrollment at a particular school. In addition, the committee recommended the Board study its policies related to enrollment to determine if revisions are warranted and to conduct community surveys to identify desired or unmet needs, priorities, and preferences. Follow this [link](#) for more information about the work of the LRAC.

Parent Knowledge and Interest Survey ([presentation/video](#))

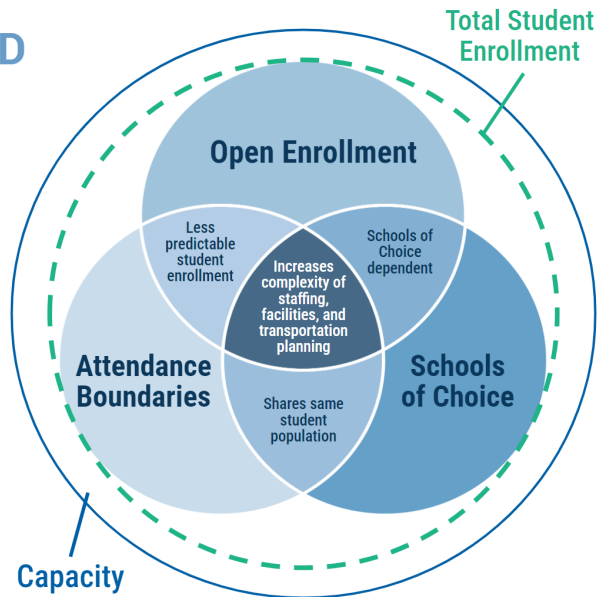
In response to LRAC's recommendations, in Sept. 2023, BVSD surveyed 1995 parents of children in 5th grade or younger in the district. Key takeaways from the [survey](#) include:

- A significant portion of parents with toddlers/infants expressed their intention to enroll their children in BVSD schools. Preferences for local neighborhood schools were prominent, with reasons including geography, convenience, good reputation, and a sense of community.
- Parents considering open-enrolling in non-neighborhood BVSD schools cited special programs/curriculum, better options than neighborhood schools, and practical considerations like sibling attendance and proximity to the workplace as key factors.
- The survey assessed parents' familiarity with various academic choice programs such as bilingual, Montessori, STEAM, and virtual learning. A notable portion of parents were either not too familiar or not at all familiar with these programs.
- Factors that influenced parents' enrollment decisions included program offerings like STEM, expeditionary learning, world languages, and gifted & talented programs.
- The minority of parents who chose not to enroll their children in BVSD schools cited reasons like schedule conflicts, religious or moral values, and a perception of better quality education at private schools.
- The survey highlights the importance of special programs, convenience, and school reputation in parents' decision-making processes for their children's education.

Enrollment Policy Worksessions

Following LRAC's recommendation, the Board engaged in a series of worksessions to study its enrollment policies. These policies have overlapping relationships with each other, and function within the overall context of total student enrollment and building capacity.

Relationship of BVSD Enrollment Policies



School Attendance Area [Policy JC](#) | Oct. 17, 2023 Work Session ([presentation](#)/[video](#))

This policy dictates that students will be assigned to a school based on the address of their residence. Attendance area boundaries will give consideration to the compactness of the area, the densities of students in an area relative to the capacities of schools, equalization of enrollments between schools, the maximization of pedestrian access and efficient use of transportation facilities. BVSD has not undertaken a district-wide review of boundaries in over 40 years.

Reasons for making boundary changes include: opening or closing schools, addressing inefficiencies, balancing student populations, optimizing resources, fostering community cohesion, and responding to demographic shifts.

Limitations and consequences include: Changing boundaries only redistributes resident populations, it does not increase the number of resident students; It is disruptive for families; There is potential for unintended consequences, It is challenging to eliminate inequalities.

Board members voiced support for developing a regular schedule for reviewing boundaries and considering a comprehensive review of existing boundaries. There was particular interest in examining dual enrollment areas and non-contiguous areas.

Open Enrollment Policy [JECC](#) & [JECC-R](#) | Oct. 24, 2023 Work Session ([presentation](#)/[video](#))

Colorado law allows students to attend any school they wish as long as space and resources are available. BVSD Policies JECC & JECC-R describe how BVSD implements this legal obligation.

BVSD provides a centralized lottery process for families to participate in. Specific preferences described in JECC-R influence where students may attend. Open enrollment generally does not include transportation, and students with disabilities have the same opportunity to open enroll as their typical peers.

With declining enrollment, families now have a much higher likelihood of being offered space at a school they applied to. Many schools that previously experienced long waitlists now are able to accommodate all students who apply through OE.

Board members had a number of comments including:

- The policies promote movement to some schools and not others - better balance is needed;
- Transportation should be considered - lack of access may be a limitation for some families. The policy should be examined with an equity lens;
- The policies should contain less detail;
- This policies include directives that should be in other policies/documents, e.g. geographic boundaries should only be referenced in Policy JC and charter school preferences should be in charter school contracts;
- Can this policy encourage out-of-district enrollment?
- The policy language should allow flexibility.

Schools of Choice [Policy IFF](#) | Nov. 14, 2023 Work Session ([presentation](#)/[video](#))

The policy is guided by Colorado's Charter Schools Law. It includes neighborhood schools and various formats like focus schools, strands, and charter schools.

Focus schools are located in Boulder and Lafayette. Students primarily attend focus schools within their city of residence.

Focus schools may be created to address an unmet educational need or to attract and/or retain students in the district or in a specific school.

Definitions of Schools of Choice:

- Neighborhood Schools: Serve students within an attendance boundary but also accept students from outside boundaries through open enrollment.
- Charter Schools: Public, non-sectarian schools operating under a charter within the district.
- Focus Schools: Include both separate schools and programs within neighborhood schools with distinct themes or philosophies.
- Neighborhood Focus Schools (Strands): Offer previously approved focus school programs or new programs developed by a school.

Board Member Comments:

- The policy is detailed like an exhibit and should be simplified.
- Making transportation more equitable needs to be considered.
- Need to consider if the policy is doing what we want it to.
- Focus schools could be used to attract students to the district or to schools with excess capacity.
- Should consider having MOUs with focus schools and creating more uniformity in how they are documented and managed.
- Should look at what is drawing students to private schools